**STATE OF PALESTINE**
Ministry of Education &
Higher Education
**Minister's Office**

دولـــة فلسطيـــن
وزارة التربية والتعليم العالي
مكتب الوزير

الرقم: و ت ع/ ٤٥١ / هـ د/ ٩٠٦

التاريخ: ٢٤/ 2 /2026م

**حضرة السادة رؤساء الجامعات الفلسطينية المحترمين**

**تحية طيبة وبعد**

**الموضوع: منتدى روما للجامعات الفلسطينية من أجل التنمية المستدامة والسلام**

**تهديكم وزارة التربية والتعليم العالي أطيب التحيات، ونتمنى لكم موفور الصحة والعافية، يسرني أن نعلمكم عن مبادرة "منتدى روما للجامعات الفلسطينية من أجل التنمية المستدامة والسلام". تهدف هذه المبادرة إلى دعم طلبة الدكتوراه الفلسطينيين في أبحاثهم، لا سيما فيما يتعلق بـ توطين وتنفيذ أهداف التنمية المستدامة (SDGs)، مع الاستفادة من أعمالهم كأداة بحثية عملية تسهم في خدمة المجتمعات المحلية ودعم عمليات صنع القرار.**

**يوفر المنتدى:**

- شبكة قوية ومرنة تربط الجامعات الفلسطينية والإيطالية، والسفارة الفلسطينية، ومنظمات المجتمع المدني، والشركاء الدوليين.
- الملكية الكاملة للجامعات الفلسطينية للأولويات والمبادرات، بدعم من الشركاء الإيطاليين والدوليين عبر الحوار، والرؤية المشتركة، والتعاون.
- إمكانية إنشاء تجمعات فلسطينية بين الجامعات وتطوير مذكرات تفاهم (MoU) مستهدفة مع الشركاء الإيطاليين، مع التركيز على أبحاث الدكتوراه والمشاريع العملية المتعلقة بأهداف التنمية المستدامة.

**يسعى المنتدى إلى بناء شراكة دولية لتعزيز البحث الأكاديمي الفلسطيني والتعاون بين الجامعات، ودعم طلبة الدكتوراه، وتشجيع المبادرات العملية للتنمية المستدامة والسلام، دون أي التزامات مالية.**

**نرفق لكم ثلاث وثائق تتعلق بالمنتدى:** (مذكرة تفاهم مع الشركاء الإيطاليين، تعيين المنسق الأكاديمي،نظام المنتدى)

**وندعوكم للمشاركة في هذه المبادرة، لما فيها من تعزيز العلاقات بين مؤسساتنا ونظيراتها الإيطالية، لتأكيد المشاركة أو الاستفسارات عن المبادرة يُرجى التواصل من خلال البريد الإلكتروني التالي: (info.aqac@mohe.pna.ps ).**

**وتقبلوا فائق التقدير والاحترام**

**د. أمجد برهم**

**وزير التربية والتعليم العالي**

نسخة: الهيئة الوطنية للاعتماد والجودة

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# Memorandum of Understanding (MoU)

between

**Rome Forum of Palestinian Universities for Sustainable Development and Peace**
(hereinafter, the "Forum")

and

***[Name of Italian Partner Institution]***
(hereinafter, the "Partner")

## Article 1 – Purpose

This Memorandum of Understanding establishes a framework for academic and institutional cooperation between the Forum and the Partner, with the objective of supporting initiatives in the fields of SDG localization for sustainable development and peace, in line with priorities identified by Palestinian universities.

This MoU is non-exclusive, non-binding in financial terms, and based on mutual interest and voluntary participation.

## Article 2 – Nature and Principles

1. The cooperation under this MoU is strictly academic, educational, and institutional in nature and carries no political mandate.
2. The Forum retains full academic ownership and leadership of its priorities and initiatives.
3. The Partner acts as a supporting and facilitating institution, not as a governing body of the Forum.

## Article 3 – Hosting and Liaison Support

1. The Partner may provide, subject to its internal rules and availability, a symbolic and light hosting function, which may include:
    - use of a mailing address or institutional reference;
    - occasional access to shared spaces for meetings or events.
2. Such hosting does not entail any structural financial obligation, including but not limited to:
    - rent,
    - utilities,
    - permanent office allocation,
    - staff costs.

3. Any concrete use of spaces, services, or resources shall occur only in connection with specific initiatives that are externally funded and expressly approved by the Partner.

## Article 4 – Areas of Cooperation

Subject to mutual agreement and external funding, cooperation may include:

- co-design initiatives for the benefit of doctoral students and post-doctoral researchers from all participating partner universities;
- joint academic events, seminars, and workshops, mainly focused on SDG localisation;
- support to doctoral action-research and local labs linked to Palestinian territories;
- co-design of project proposals with international donors and multilateral organizations.

Each activity shall be governed by a separate written agreement or addendum, specifying roles, budgets, and responsibilities.

## Article 5 – Financial Provisions

1. This MoU does not create any financial obligation for either Party.
2. All activities requiring financial resources shall be undertaken only:
    - upon confirmation of external funding;
    - with explicit approval by the competent bodies of the participating institutions.
3. Financial management arrangements shall be defined case by case in separate agreements.

## Article 6 – Use of Name, Logo, and Communication

1. Neither Party shall use the name or logo of the other Party without prior written consent.
2. Public communication related to joint activities shall be coordinated to ensure accuracy, neutrality, and institutional consistency.

## Article 7 – Duration and Termination

1. This MoU enters into force on the date of signature and is valid for three (3) years, renewable by mutual written agreement.

2. Either Party may terminate this MoU with 60 days' written notice, without prejudice to activities already underway under separate agreements.

## Article 8 – Non-Exclusivity

This MoU does not restrict either Party from engaging in other partnerships or initiatives with third parties.

## Article 9 – Governing Law and Dispute Resolution

This MoU is governed by principles of good faith and cooperation. Any dispute shall be resolved amicably through consultation between the Parties.

**Signed for the Forum:**

**Name:** _____

**Name and Title of Signatory:** _____

**Signature:** _____

**Date:** _____

**Signed for the Partner:**

**Name:** _____

**Name and Title of Signatory:** _____

**Signature:** _____

**Date:** _____

ANNEX A

# Decision on the Initial Appointment of the Academic Coordinator of the Rome Liaison Office

**Rome Forum of Palestinian Universities for Sustainable Development and Peace**

*(Liaison Office)*

The Council of Member Universities of the Rome Forum of Palestinian Universities for Sustainable Development and Peace,

recalling Article 9 of the Statute, and in order to ensure institutional continuity and operational coordination during the start-up phase,

hereby appoints

Prof. Marco Zupi – Professor of Development Policy and International Political Economy, currently serving as Scientific Coordinator of the UN Local2030 Knowledge and Scientific Network (KSN) – as Academic Coordinator of the Rome Liaison Office, for an initial period of twelve (12) months from the date of entry into force of the Statute, renewable by Council decision.

Prof. Zupi shall serve pro bono, acting as liaison and academic focal point in Rome, under the strategic guidance of the Council and the Presidents/Rectors of Member Universities, and shall report regularly to the Council.

This appointment does not create financial obligations for Member Universities or for any host institution, and may be revised at any time by Council decision.

Signed on behalf of the Member Universities:

**Signature**

For the Founding University:

Name of University: _____

President/Rector: _____

Date: _____

Signature: _____

# Statute (Founding Charter)

**Rome Forum of Palestinian Universities for Sustainable Development and Peace**

*(Liaison Office)*

## Preamble

The undersigned Palestinian Universities,

- reaffirming their commitment to higher education, scientific research, and the public mission of universities in serving society;
- acknowledging the severe and prolonged challenges faced by Palestinian academic institutions and communities, and the need to strengthen Palestinian academic ownership, resilience, and international presence;
- recognizing the central role of doctoral education and early-career researchers in supporting evidence-based policymaking, territorial development, and the localization of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs);
- inspired by the principles and practices promoted within the United Nations system, including the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development and the Local2030 Coalition Knowledge and Scientific Network (KSN) approach to science-policy-territory interfaces;

hereby agree to establish a structured academic forum, based in Rome, as a shared platform for coordination, representation, and international academic cooperation.

## Article 1 – Establishment and Seat

1. The undersigned Palestinian university hereby establishes the Rome Forum of Palestinian Universities for Sustainable Development and Peace (hereinafter, the "Forum") as a joint academic initiative.
2. The Forum shall operate through a Rome Liaison Office, intended as a symbolic and functional academic liaison presence in Rome
3. The Rome Liaison Office shall be supported through one or more separate Memoranda of Understanding (the "MoU") with Italian academic and institutional partners, defining hosting modalities, partnership modalities and forms of cooperation, without creating structural financial or administrative obligations for the partners.
4. The Forum does not constitute a separate legal entity unless unanimously decided otherwise by the Member Universities at a later stage.

## Article 2 – Definitions

For the purposes of this Statute:

a) "Member University" means any Palestinian university that has signed this Statute or has subsequently acceded to it in accordance with Article 6.
b) "Forum" means the Rome Forum of Palestinian Universities for Sustainable Development and Peace.
c) "Rome Liaison Office" means the Forum's coordination and representation function based in Rome.
d) "Initiative" or "Activity" means any project, program, training, research, or event carried out within the framework of the Forum.
e) "KSN-inspired approach" refers to an academic methodology centered on the science–policy–territory interface, with a focus on doctoral action-research and the localization of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).

## Article 3 – Nature, Principles, and Neutrality

1. The Forum is strictly academic, non-political, non-partisan, and non-representative of any governmental authority.
2. The Forum is guided by the principles of:
    - Palestinian academic ownership and leadership;
    - equality among Member Universities;
    - academic freedom and scientific integrity;
    - solidarity and mutual support;
    - alignment with the UN 2030 Agenda and SDG localization.
3. The Forum does not aim to promote individual or permanent academic mobility detached from Palestinian institutions, but rather to strengthen Palestinian universities and doctoral programs through structured international cooperation.

## Article 4 – Purpose and Objectives

The purpose of the Forum is to provide a collective Palestinian academic interface in Rome in order to:

1. place doctoral candidates and early-career researchers at the center of international cooperation;
2. promote action-oriented research supporting SDG localization in Palestinian territories (cities, regions, and communities);
3. facilitate joint academic initiatives, including doctoral clusters, local labs, policy-oriented research, and scientific dissemination;

4. engage Italian, European, and international academic and institutional partners on an equal and partnership-based footing, in line with priorities defined by Palestinian universities.

## Article 5 – Scope of Activities

Forum activities may include, subject to approval by participating Member Universities:

- joint doctoral training modules and seminars;
- applied research and "local labs" linked to Palestinian territories;
- preparation of policy briefs and similar outputs;
- development of funding proposals with international partners;
- academic events and dissemination activities facilitated through Rome.

## Article 6 – Membership

1. Membership in the Forum is open to Palestinian universities that endorse the principles and objectives of this Statute.
2. Additional Palestinian universities may join the Forum at any time by submitting a written request, subject to acknowledgment by the Council (Article 7).
3. Each Member University shall designate one institutional focal point for coordination with the Forum.

## Article 7 – Governance: Council of Member Universities

1. The Forum shall be governed by a Council of Member Universities, composed of the Presidents/Rectors of Member Universities or their formally designated representatives.
2. The Council shall:
    - define the strategic orientations of the Forum;
    - approve Initiatives and partnerships;
    - appoint or confirm the Academic Coordinator of the Rome Liaison Office;
    - oversee the implementation of this Statute.

## Article 8 – Decision-Making

### 8.1 Consensus and Qualified Majority

1. Decisions shall be taken by consensus whenever possible.

2. Where consensus cannot be reached, decisions shall require a qualified majority of two-thirds (2/3) of Member Universities present and voting. The Council may refine this rule by subsequent decision.

### 8.2 Variable Geometry (Opt-in Participation)

3. Participation in specific Initiatives or Activities shall be voluntary.
   One or more Member Universities may decide to participate in a given Initiative, while others may choose not to do so, without prejudice to their status within the Forum.
   Such Initiatives shall be carried out under the auspices of the Forum by the participating Member Universities only.

## Article 9 – Rome Liaison Office and Academic Coordination

1. The Forum shall designate an Academic Coordinator of the Rome Liaison Office.
2. The Academic Coordinator shall act as the Forum's academic and institutional liaison in Rome, under the strategic guidance of the Council.
3. The Academic Coordinator shall:
   - liaise with the Italian host institution and other partners;
   - ensure coherence with Council decisions;
   - report regularly to the Council on activities and developments.
4. The Academic Coordinator shall serve pro bono, unless otherwise decided by the Council and subject to external funding.
5. The appointment of the Academic Coordinator of the Rome Liaison Office shall be effected through a separate Appointment Act, which may be signed sequentially by member universities upon accession to the Forum.

## Article 10 – Partnership Framework and Next Institutional Step

1. The Forum may establish cooperation agreements with Italian and international universities and, where appropriate, with multilateral organizations, subject to Council approval.
2. The next institutional step following the adoption of this Statute shall be the negotiation and signature of MoU with Italian academic and partner institutions, defining hosting modalities, liaison arrangements, and coordination mechanisms, without structural financial obligations for the host institution.

## Article 11 – Financial Principles

1. The Forum shall not generate any automatic financial obligations for Member Universities or host institutions.
2. Activities shall be undertaken only where external funding is secured and following approval by the competent bodies of participating universities.
3. Financial management arrangements for specific Initiatives shall be defined in separate written agreements.

## Article 12 – Non-Exclusivity

Participation in the Forum is additional and complementary to other forms of international cooperation pursued by Member Universities.

Nothing in this Statute shall limit the right of any Member University to engage independently or jointly in other academic partnerships.

## Article 13 – Entry into Force, Amendments, and Duration

1. This Statute shall enter into force upon signature by at least one (1) Palestinian university.
2. Upon entry into force, the Forum shall be deemed duly constituted and operational, notwithstanding the subsequent accession of additional universities.
3. This Statute shall remain open for accession by other Palestinian universities in accordance with Article 14 below.
4. The Forum is conceived as an open and evolving academic framework, with the explicit objective of progressively including additional Palestinian universities as founding or member institutions.
5. The Statute shall remain in force until terminated by unanimous decision of the Council.

## Article 14 – Accession of Additional Universities

1. Any Palestinian university that shares the principles and objectives of the Forum may accede to this Statute at any time.
2. Accession shall take effect upon signature of an Accession Page or Signature Page referring explicitly to this Statute, without the need to amend or re-execute the present Statute.
3. Upon accession, the university shall enjoy the same rights and responsibilities as other member universities, in accordance with this Statute.

4. The Secretariat of the Forum shall circulate a notification of accession to all member universities for information purposes.

## Article 15 – Amendments to the Statute

1. Amendments to this Statute may be proposed by the Council or by any member university.
2. Amendments shall be adopted by consensus whenever possible, or otherwise by a qualified majority as defined by the Council.
3. Adopted amendments shall be communicated in writing to all member universities.
4. Unless a member university objects in writing within sixty (60) days from the date of notification, the amendment shall be deemed accepted and shall enter into force on the date specified by the Council.
5. Amendments shall not require re-signature of the entire Statute, unless they alter the fundamental nature of the Forum.

## Signature

(to be signed separately by each university)

By signing this document, … *[WRITE: Full official name of the University]*, duly represented by its Rector/President or authorized signatory, hereby formally accedes to and accepts the Statute (Founding Charter) of the Rome Forum of Palestinian Universities for Sustainable Development and Peace, and commits to uphold its principles, objectives, and governance provisions.

This accession shall take effect on the date of signature below.

**Name of University:** _____

**Name and Title of Signatory:** _____

**Signature:** _____

**Date:** _____

**Place:** _____